



Modelling Venetian Renaissance Writing: The Case of Veronica Franco

An introduction to Veronica Franco

Venice Summer School
in Digital and Public Humanities

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Veronica Franco (1546–1591)

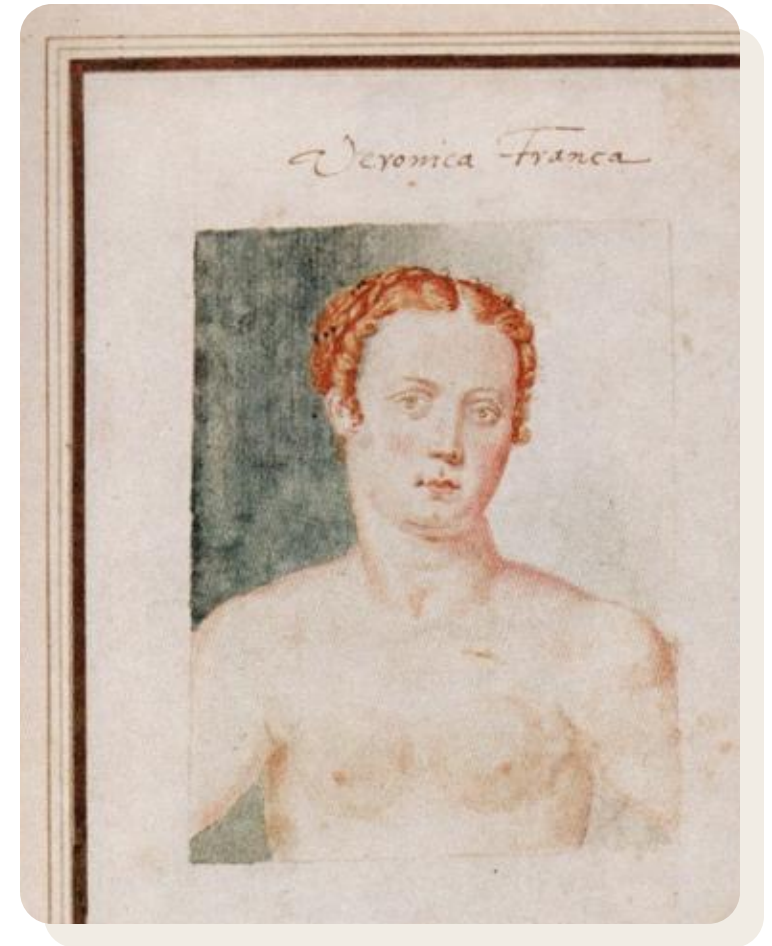
Poet · Courtesan · Intellectual

One of the most remarkable women writers of Renaissance Venice.

Cultivated a humanist education that enabled her to enter Venice's literary circles.

Member of **Ca' Venier**, one of Venice's leading literary salons.

Author of *Terze Rime* (1575) and *Lettere familiari a diversi* (1580).



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The Letter to Henry III

From Private Correspondence to Public Literature

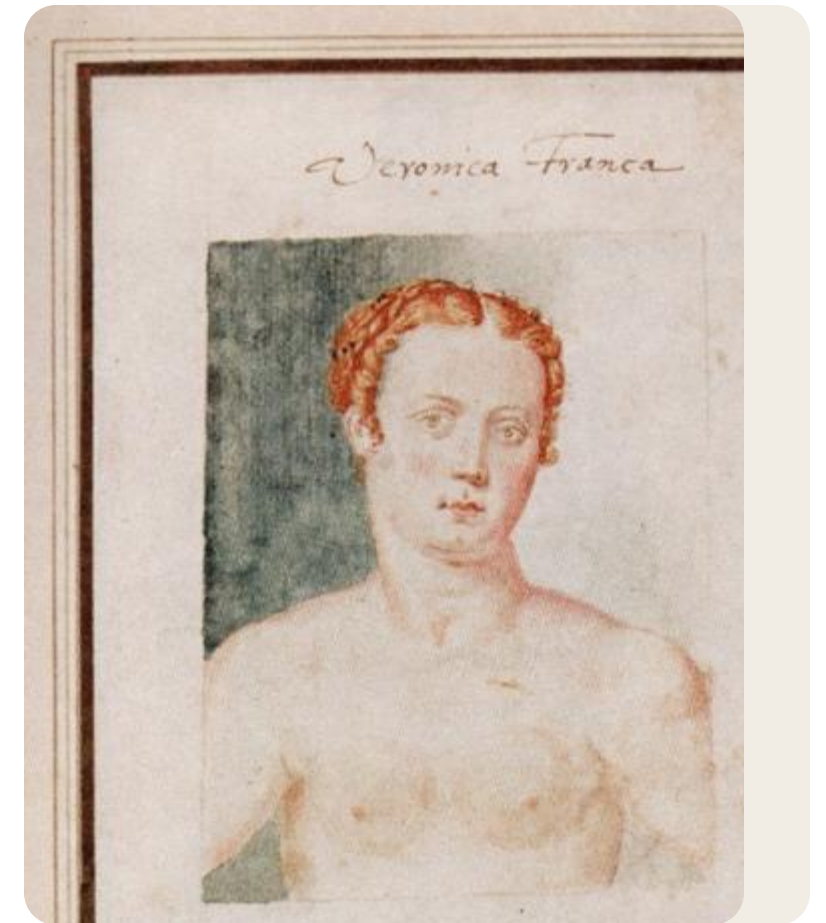
Henry III visited Venice in **1574**.

Veronica Franco dedicated to him a letter, two sonnets and her portrait.

The collection is dedicated to **Cardinal Luigi d'Este**.

The autograph manuscript has not survived.

The only surviving version is the printed edition of **1580**.



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Why Venice Matters

Print, Gender and Public Voice

A City of Print

- Venice was Europe's leading printing centre, with hundreds of active presses and an international book trade.
- Books circulated widely, reaching scholars, diplomats and courts across the Mediterranean.
- Publishing transformed private writing into public culture and made literary reputation possible.

A City of Women's Voices

- The *cortigiana onesta* occupied an ambivalent position, negotiating education and autonomy.
- Veronica Franco transformed that position into a space for authorship and public visibility.

A City of Archives

- Venice preserves one of Europe's richest documentary collections.
- Senate deliberations, notarial records, and trials reconstruct the historical world of Veronica Franco.
- These are the documents we will encounter at the **Archivio di Stato di Venezia**.



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1580: A Turning Point

Venice after the plague (1575–1577)

- The plague reshaped Venetian society, strengthening moral and religious control.
- Courtesans became the object of increasing legal regulation and social suspicion.
- Veronica Franco herself was tried before the Holy Office in **1580** and eventually acquitted.

Why publish *Lettere familiari a diversi*?

- The collection can be read as a response to this changing social climate.
- By transforming private correspondence into a printed literary work, Veronica Franco reclaimed her public voice and reshaped her reputation.
- The letter to **Henry III** places her within an international network of political and literary authority, reinforcing her status as an author rather than simply a celebrated courtesan.

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